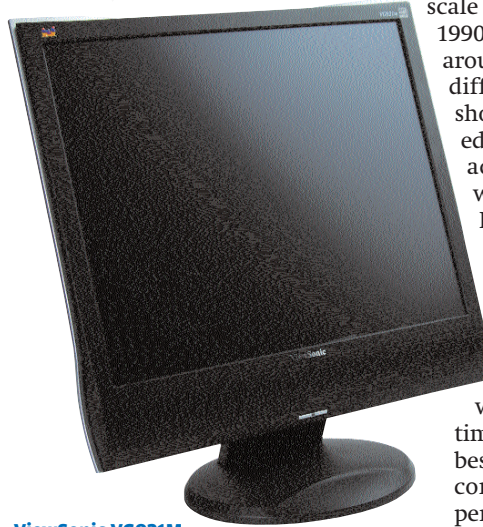


Among the others, the Intex 1904w and both the ViewSonic models looked quite sleek; the latter had better colour combinations while the 1904w had a slimmer bezel. Another beauty that caught our eye was AOC's 197S—very good build quality and top notch fit and finish. The quality of moving parts was also up there. The two big boys from NEC (MultiSync 1990FX and MultiSync 1970NXp) also sport excellent finish and supreme build quality.

The HP L1940T features height adjustment—a feature all other 19-inch monitors (besides NEC's duo mentioned above) missed out on. One welcome feature on the MultiSync 1990FX was the presence of portrait mode and you can actually tilt the screen to view web pages vertically, so there's less scrolling. The MultiSync 1990FX had one of the slimmest bezels of all, the only lament was the finish—while excellent in quality it looked rather plain.

The NEC MultiSync 1970NXp featured a very cell phone-like 5-way joystick for menu selection and navigation. It works very well, and reduces the time taken to tinker with the monitors settings—once you get used to it. Another nifty feature unique to this monitor is a trick horizontal swivel. The 1970NXp has a heavy metal base covered with plastic trim. Now when you attempt to turn the screen left and right the entire screen turns, while the metal base remains firm on the table. We say 'trick' because it doesn't appear at first to be able to swivel horizontally.

Exploring connectivity options the ViewSonic duo (VG921M and VA1912W) were in the limelight for the wrong reasons this time—they don't have DVI connects—very shocking for the 19-inch category. Also guilty of this offense by omission were AOC's 197S, HP's L1916, Intex's 1904w, LG's 1952S, and NEC's own LCD190V. None of the 19-inchers featured HDCP support, which means HDCP protected content will not work on these monitors.



ViewSonic VG921M
A birds eye view

Of Speed And Visual Quality

DisplayMate may be Jurassic to some, but it sure helps separate the wheat from the chaff as far as quality goes. One monitor that left the others wallowing in its wake with its sheer dominance

in DisplayMate's colour and gray-scale tests was NEC's MultiSync 1990FX. It was the only LCD based around an S-IPS panel, and the difference in colour rendition shows clearly. If you're an image editing professional who wants accurate colour rendition when working with Photoshop or want accurate point-scaling when rendering, the MultiSync 1990FX is the monitor for you. Gamers will also notice the difference in colours, although S-IPS panels are plagued with slower pixel response times, and this may not be the best solution for games (cost considered). The 1990FX also performed commendably in the sharpness and resolution tests,

just short of the MVA panel-based MultiSync 1970NXp.

Though most people will prefer widescreen monitors for movie-watching, the wide viewing angles that S-IPS and MVA panels provide are much better than TN panels—meaning both these NECs are capable multimedia solutions. The bitter pill in both cases is the price.

A (hefty) notch lower in performance are the offerings from ViewSonic (VG921M) and HP (L1916, L1940T)—both monitors offered some very good results throughout the tests. These were very closely trailed by the LCDs from AOC, BenQ and ASUS. The PG191 had vivid and crisp colours, but the intensity of the colours seemed artificially rich—some tuning was in order. The dark horse was BenQ's FP92W. Despite the fact that it won no accolades it performed reasonably well in DisplayMate, it really came into its own with the movie and game tests. The HDR effects in Oblivion were literally eye-hurting—this smacks of a good contrast ratio—just what the doctor ordered for multimedia activities. The fact that this is a 16:10 (widescreen) monitor just adds to its appeal for the said audience.

HP's L1916 despite being a good scorer had one niggling issue—slight backlight bleeding. This killjoy makes its presence felt on a dark background.

There were no "really bad performers" this time round—all manufacturers are focusing on capturing the flat panel market, so they wouldn't dare introduce sub-standard stuff. However, there were those monitors which had minor issues, or performed consistently behind the others—sometimes both. Jetway's JM1941DF was one such monitor. We were unlucky to get a piece with an eyesore of a dead pixel. However, this is a one off issue, and dead pixels usually mean immediate replacements—so peace! There were also some issues with the black shift test—there were noticeable differences in the grey-coloured

Jargon Buster

Backlight Bleeding: The surface of an LCD is backlit by CCFLs (Cold Cathode Fluorescent Lamps). The liquid crystals inside the panel orient themselves to block out all light when off, and re-orient so to allow light to pass through when on. The angle of this orientation determines the colour of the light we see.

Backlight bleeding occurs when this light is not completely blocked out, allowing some of it to "bleed" through. It's noticeable on a black background, where some areas will have lighter flecks or bands than other areas. It's a problem that plagues a majority of LCDs out there. The good thing is that it's not very visible during regular work.

Pixel Response Times: This is the time taken for liquid crystals to switch on and off. Liquid crystals orient themselves to switch on and off by application of an electric current, and the time taken for this orientation is called Pixel Response Times.

Dithering: Dithering is nothing but digital noise introduced to simulate many shades of colour, starting with fewer shades. In LCDs, 6-bit panels (262,144 colours) are dithered to display 16.7 million colours (8-bit). Dithering is, simply put, interpolation and will never be as effective as true 24-bit colour. However, 6-bit panels are cheaper to manufacture making it a price-performance trade-off of sorts.

Nits: Nits is better known as candela per square meter. It is a measurement of screen brightness for all displays. Mathematically, Nits is Cd/m^2 .